



Introduction to Module 4



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“I keep probing ideas and fumble to give them form,” Sheila Hicks has said about her process.

“Everyone has a relationship to material....There’s a hop, skip and a jump that takes you from material to art and often it’s circuitous.” We’ll start this module with Hicks, who has been pushing the boundaries of fibers over the course of her 60-year career. Her work offers a good entry point for our focus here on the stuff of art, on how it is made, and on who or what makes it.



There’s nothing that can’t be made into art. Artists have proven this over and over again, with no end in sight to their experimentation. In this module, you’ll find familiar materials like photographs and film—albeit not always handled in traditional ways—as well as unexpected substances like ultrasonic gel, a monumental sheet of vinyl, coffee grounds, and parts of demolished houses. You’ll discover why these diverse materials attracted the artists here and how they have given them shape and meaning.

You’ll also explore how some artists working today embrace traditional methods of making, including putting brush to canvas, and others who take practices like choreography to new settings such as a factory. Finally, two approaches to 3-D printed architecture take us into the realm of experimentation for a more sustainable future.

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